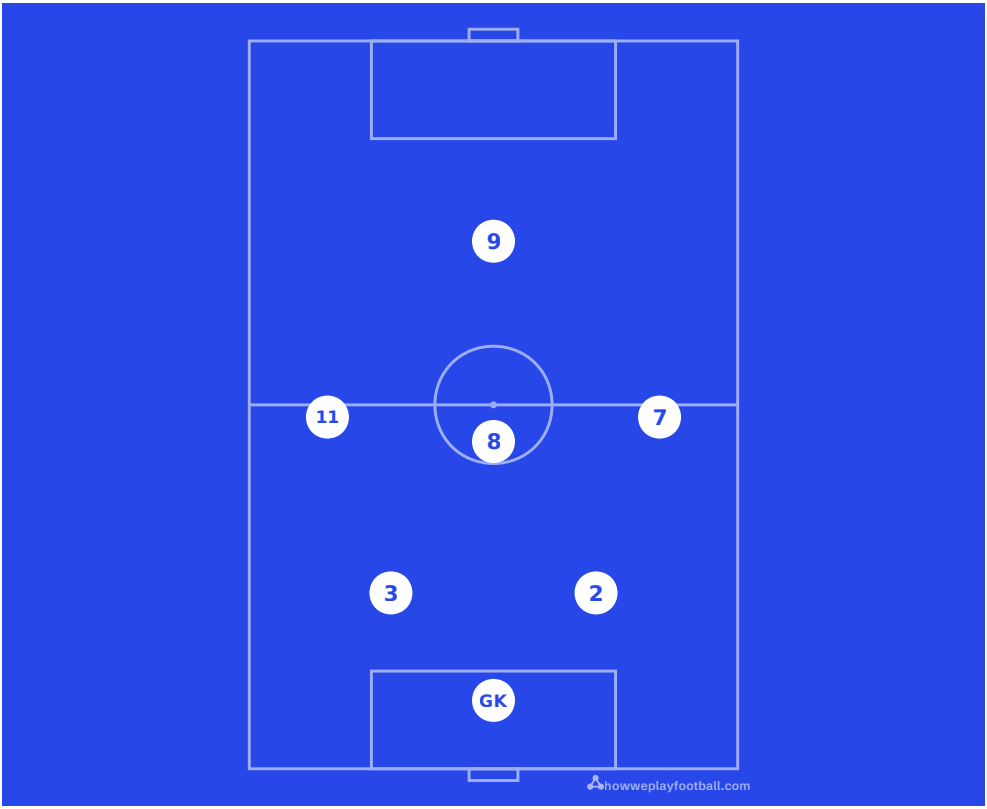
7V7 FORMATION GUIDE

2-3-1

A starting shape, four playing principles and a job for every position.



INTRODUCTION

WELCOME

Moving from 5v5 to 7v7 means two more players and more decisions. The 2-3-1 gives us a starting picture: two defenders, three midfielders and a striker, supported by the goalkeeper. Four simple ideas help players play together, without locking anyone into a role.

WHO IT'S FOR

Volunteer grassroots football coaches and parents looking for a shared starting picture for 7v7.

The shape helps us explain jobs. Players should still have opportunities to try different roles.

HOW TO USE IT

- Learn the starting shape.
- Pick one of the four principles to talk about.
- Give each player a short, useful question.
- Use the online diagrams when you want to see movement.

IN THIS GUIDE

01 Starting shape

02 Four playing principles

03 A job for every player

04 Coaching reminders and notes

HOW TO READ THIS GUIDE

READING THE DIAGRAMS

We always attack up the page. These pictures capture a moment, not a fixed running lane.

8

OUR PLAYER

A blue player with a number.

THEM

A player from the opposition.

BALL

Where the ball is in this moment.

MOVEMENT

A solid arrow shows a possible run.

PASS

A broken arrow can show a pass.

SPACE

A highlighted area draws your eye to a decision.



7V7 · 2-3-1

A STARTING SHAPE, NOT A FIXED PLAN FOR EVERY SECOND.

7v7 · The 2-3-1 · howweplayfootball.com

The numbers identify jobs in the drawings. They do not lock children into one position.

CHAPTER 01 · THE STARTING PICTURE

STARTING SHAPE

Moving from 5v5 to 7v7 means two more players and more decisions. The 2-3-1 gives us a starting picture: two defenders, three midfielders and a striker, supported by the goalkeeper. Four simple ideas help players play together, without locking anyone into a role.



7v7 · The 2-3-1 · Indicative player starting positions

THIS SHAPE GIVES US

- two defenders learning to support each other
- width from the wide midfielders
- a central midfielder linking both ends
- a striker who can offer depth or a short pass
- simple decisions when possession changes

REMEMBER

SAME STARTING SHAPE. DIFFERENT DECISIONS AS THE BALL MOVES.

CHAPTER 02 · HOW WE PLAY

FOUR PRINCIPLES

Small decisions the whole team can recognise and talk about.

01 GIVE TWO OPTIONS

Help our goalkeeper start play without forcing a pass. The two defenders spread out to offer clear passes; 8 can support ahead.

“Can our keeper see two choices?”

02 BIG WITH IT, SMALL WITHOUT IT

Use the width when we attack; get closer when we defend. 11 and 7 stretch the pitch in possession and recover inside without it.

“Ball ours? Wide. Ball theirs? Closer.”

03 ONE PRESSES, ONE COVERS

When one defender meets the ball, the other protects the danger behind. Two defenders work as a pair, not both chasing the same opponent.

“If your mate goes, where do you cover?”

04 LOSE IT, FIND HOME

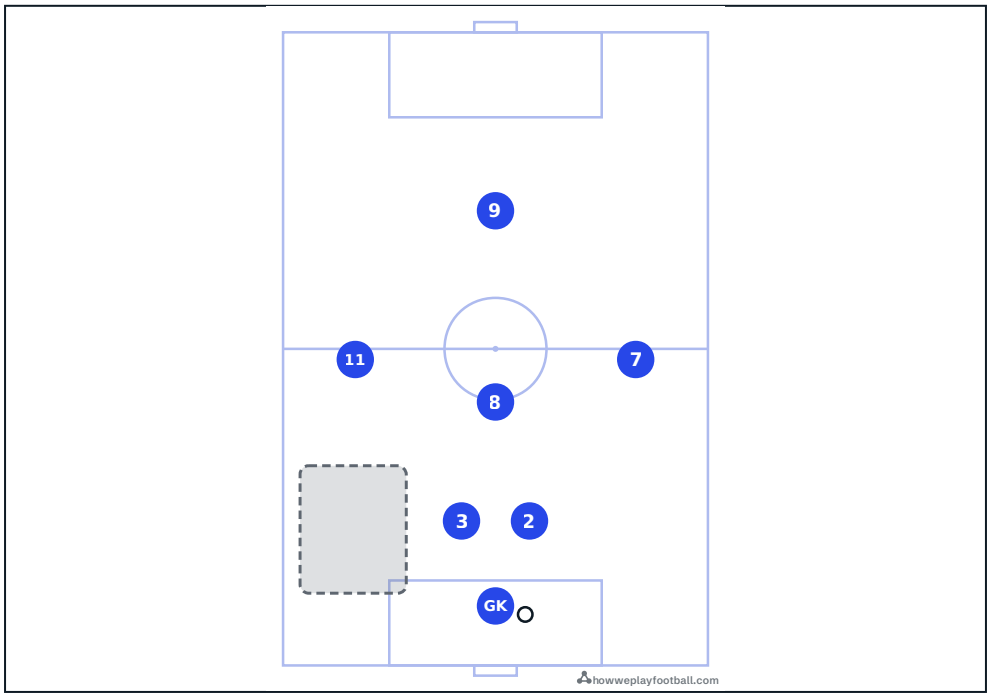
Recover together when possession changes. The closest player slows the attack while teammates recover to protect the middle.

“Who slows them? Where do I help?”

PRINCIPLE 01 OF 04 · PICTURE ONE

GIVE TWO OPTIONS

Help our goalkeeper start play without forcing a pass. The two defenders spread out to offer clear passes; 8 can support ahead.



TOO CLOSE

Both defenders come too close together. The goalkeeper has fewer clear passing angles.

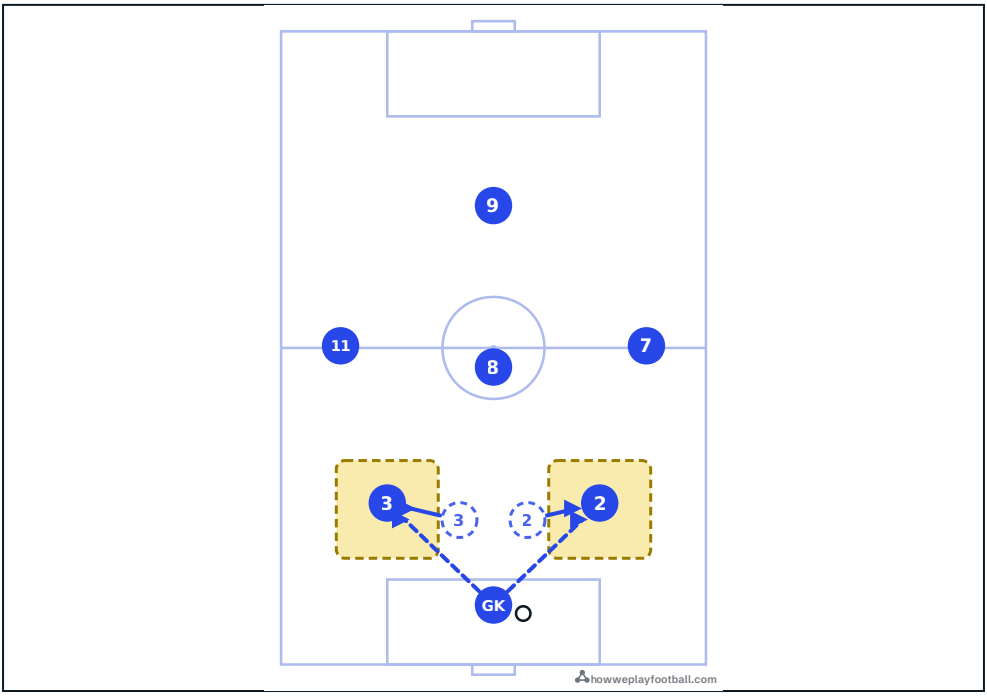
SAY IT

“CAN OUR KEEPER SEE TWO CHOICES?”

Look short when it is safe. If it isn't on, don't force it.

PRINCIPLE 01 OF 04 · PICTURE TWO

GIVE TWO OPTIONS



GIVE TWO OPTIONS

3 and 2 split to offer safe passing angles. 8 stays available ahead. Look short if it is on.

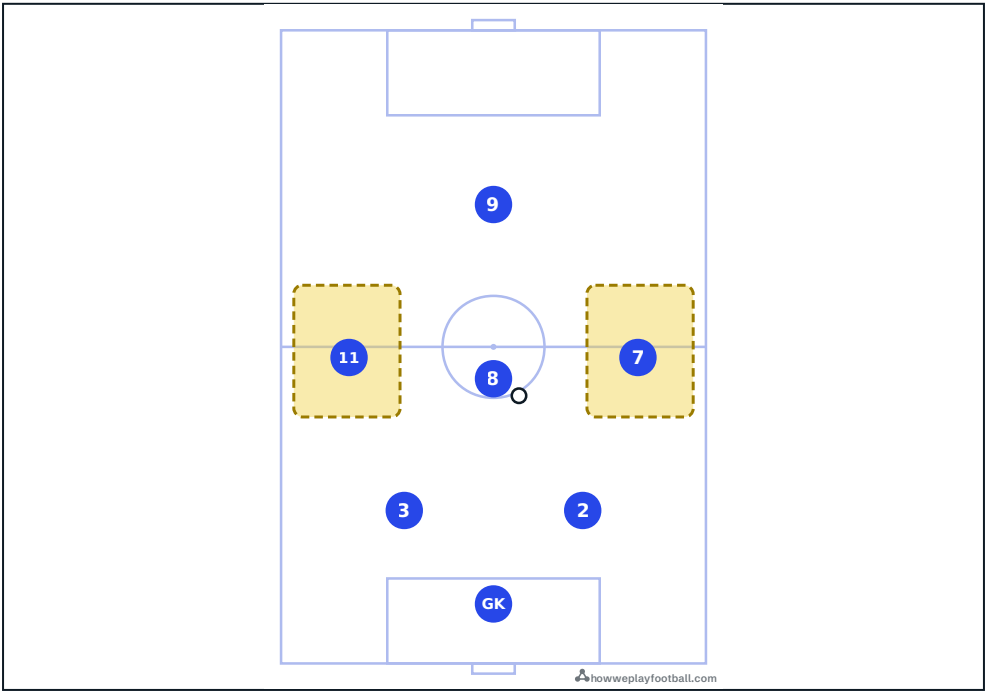
WHAT TO LOOK FOR

- 3 and 2 separate to offer the goalkeeper passing angles.
- 8 stays available ahead as a potential next pass, rather than hiding behind an opponent.
- If no safe short pass is available, players aren't forced into one.

PRINCIPLE 02 OF 04 · PICTURE ONE

BIG WITH IT, SMALL WITHOUT IT

Use the width when we attack; get closer when we defend. 11 and 7 stretch the pitch in possession and recover inside without it.



BALL OURS: BIG

11 and 7 stretch the pitch. 8 offers a central passing option, with 9 ahead.

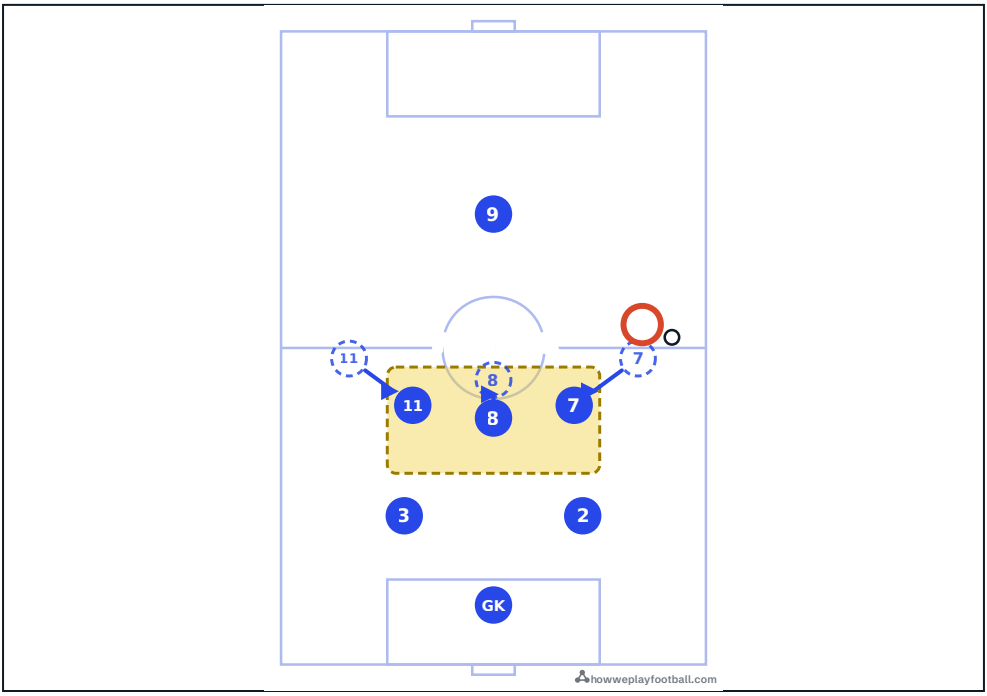
SAY IT

“BALL OURS? WIDE. BALL THEIRS? CLOSER.”

Starting positions help us; they're not painted lines on the pitch.

PRINCIPLE 02 OF 04 · PICTURE TWO

BIG WITH IT, SMALL WITHOUT IT



BALL THEIRS: CLOSER

11 and 7 recover inside to help 8 protect the middle. The team stays connected.

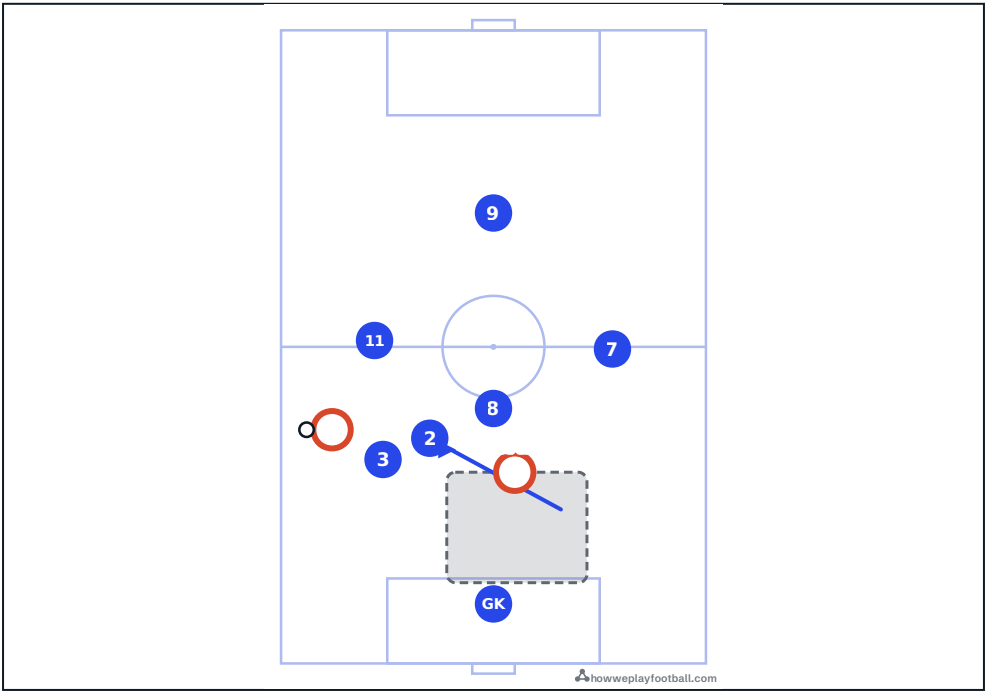
WHAT TO LOOK FOR

- When we have the ball, the wide midfielders give their teammates room and an outside pass.
- When the opposition have it, the wide midfielders move closer to 8 and help protect the middle.
- The whole team responds to the ball; wide players aren't trapped in channels.

PRINCIPLE 03 OF 04 · PICTURE ONE

ONE PRESSES, ONE COVERS

When one defender meets the ball, the other protects the danger behind. Two defenders work as a pair, not both chasing the same opponent.



WRONG: BOTH CHASE

Both defenders chase the same player. Space opens behind them.

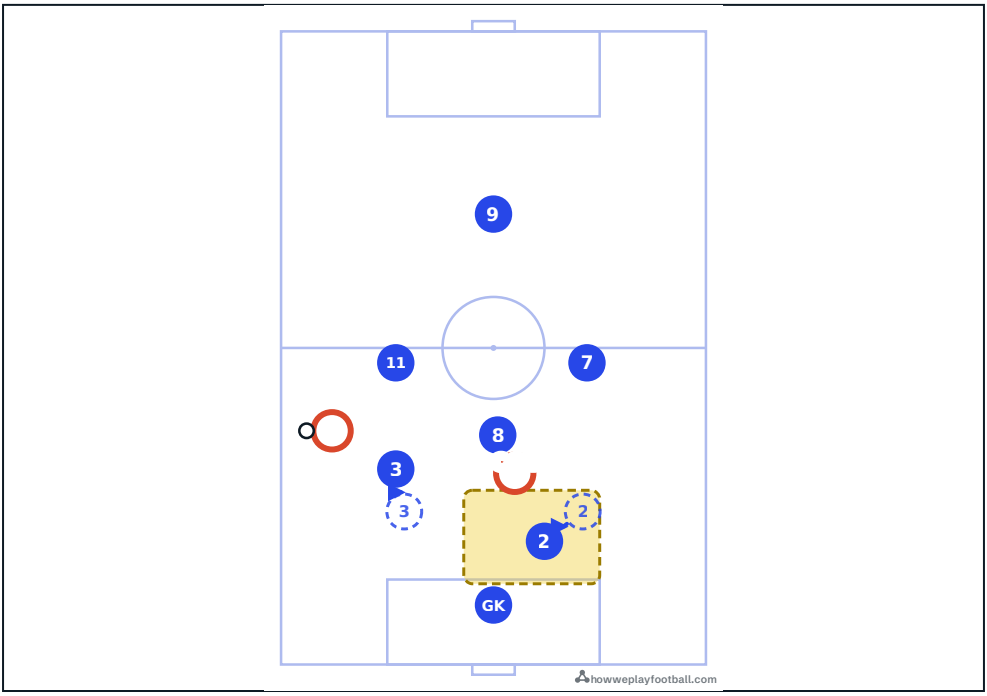
SAY IT

“IF YOUR MATE GOES, WHERE DO YOU COVER?”

Don't leave your partner defending the goal alone.

PRINCIPLE 03 OF 04 · PICTURE TWO

ONE PRESSES, ONE COVERS



RIGHT: PRESS AND COVER

3 can meet the ball. 2 protects the space behind, and 8 helps in the middle.

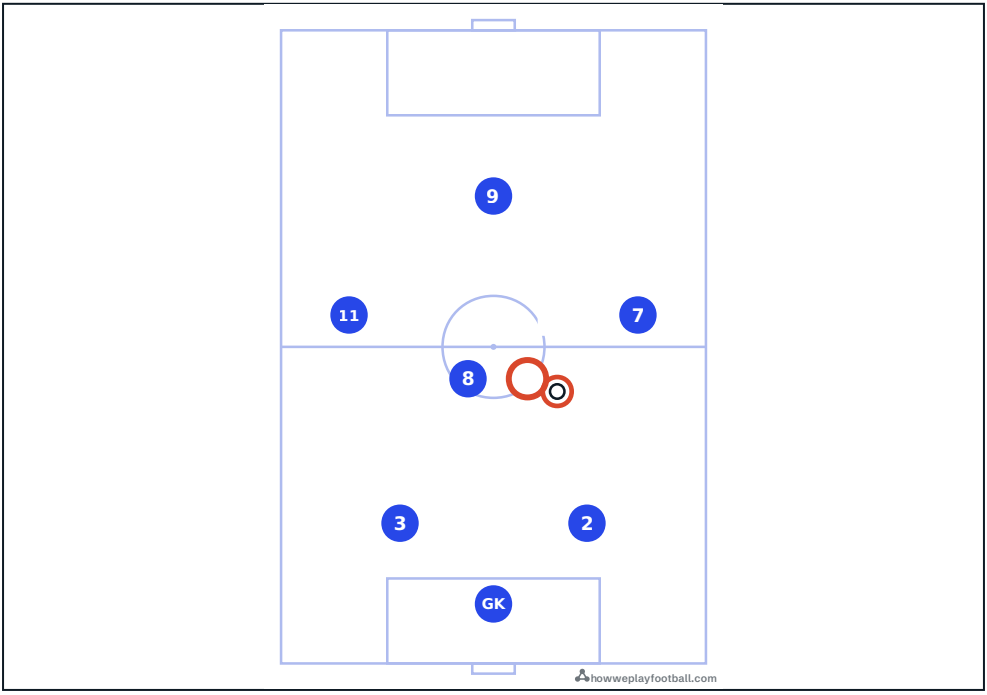
WHAT TO LOOK FOR

- The closest defender chooses whether to meet the ball.
- The other defender protects the route towards goal.
- Our central midfielder helps close the space ahead rather than abandoning the centre.

PRINCIPLE 04 OF 04 · PICTURE ONE

LOSE IT, FIND HOME

Recover together when possession changes. The closest player slows the attack while teammates recover to protect the middle.



WHEN WE LOSE IT

The ball has changed hands. We have players ahead of it, so we need to recover together.

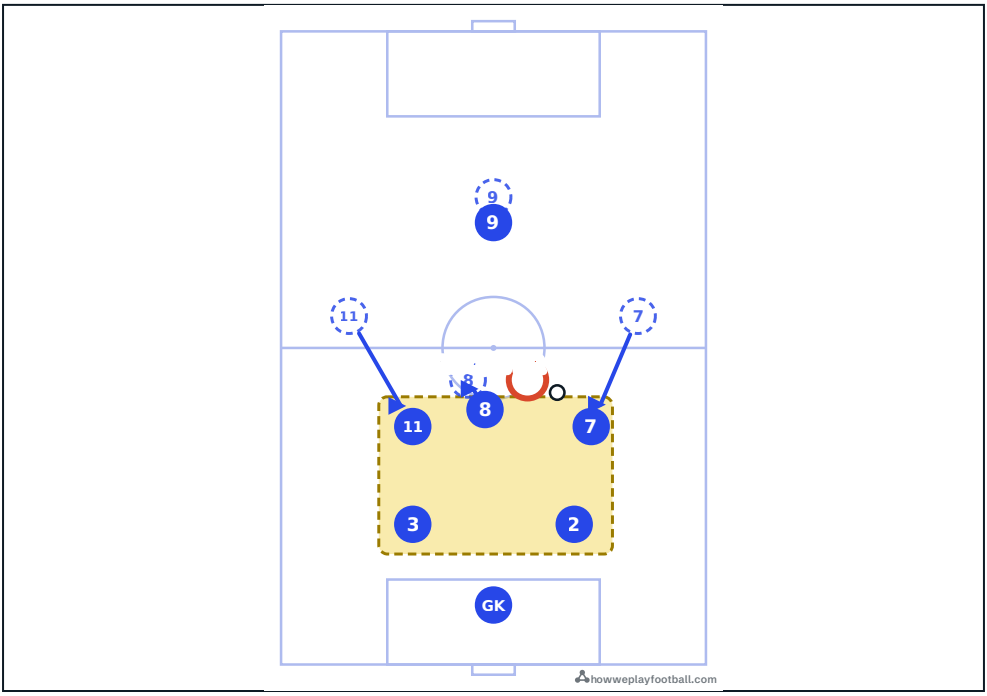
SAY IT

“WHO SLOWS THEM? WHERE DO I HELP?”

You don't all have to win the ball. Give the team time to get organised.

PRINCIPLE 04 OF 04 · PICTURE TWO

LOSE IT, FIND HOME



NEAREST SLOWS, OTHERS RECOVER

8 slows the next attack. 11 and 7 move back towards the middle while 3 and 2 protect our goal.

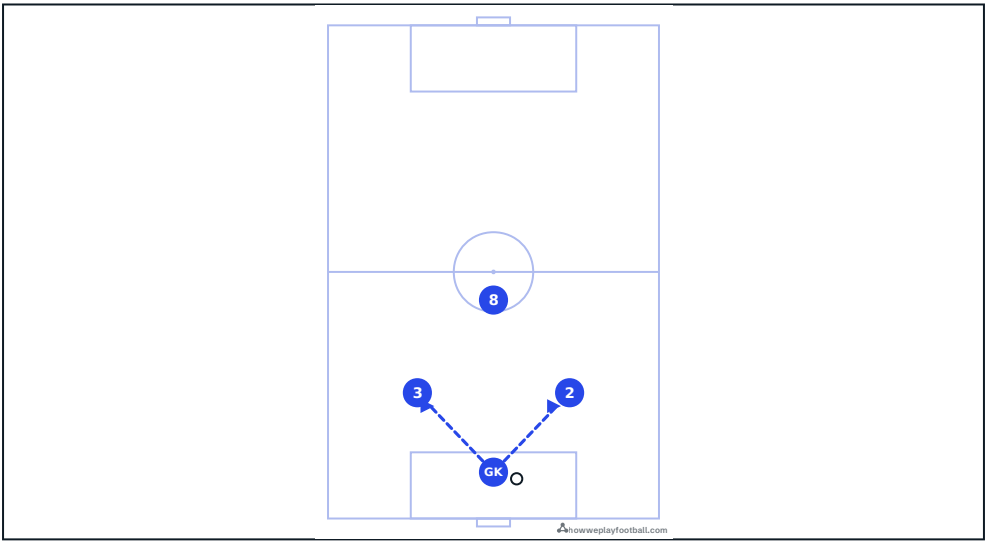
WHAT TO LOOK FOR

- The nearest player slows the opposition if it's safe to do so.
- Both wide midfielders recover to help the team get connected.
- The defender pair protects the route to our goal.

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

GK GOALKEEPER

Start us playing



YOUR JOBS

- Look for safe passing options to our two defenders.
- Try a short pass when the picture is clear; do not force it if the pass is blocked.
- Help the team with calm information when the other side has the ball.

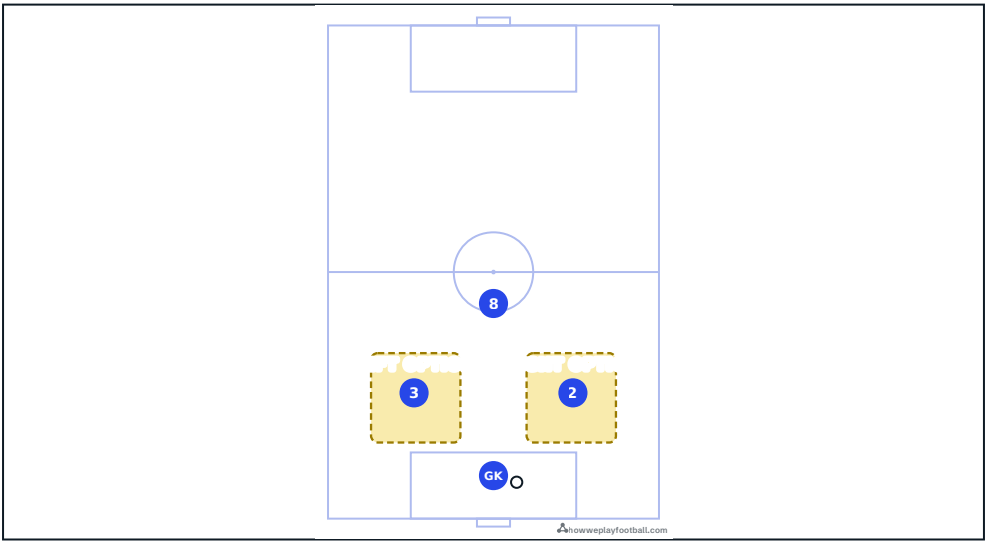
ASK YOURSELF

“CAN I SEE TWO GOOD CHOICES?”

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

3 · 2 THE TWO DEFENDERS

Give options. Protect together.



YOUR JOBS

- With the ball, move apart enough to be seen by our goalkeeper.
- When the opposition attack, work together: one can meet the danger, the other covers.
- Stay close enough that you can help one another when possession changes.

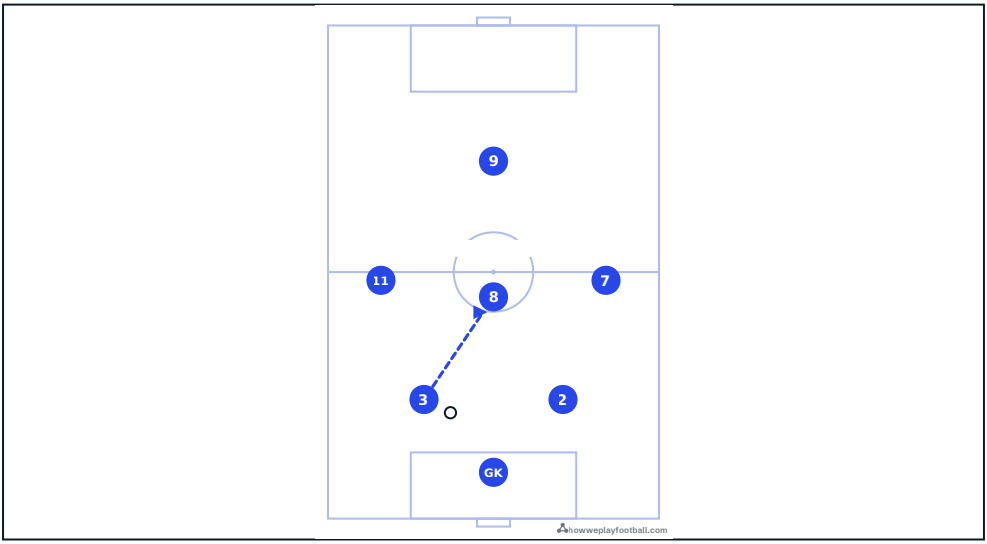
ASK YOURSELF

“IF MY PARTNER GOES, WHERE SHOULD I BE?”

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

8 CENTRAL MIDFIELDER

Connect the team



YOUR JOBS

- Make yourself available for a pass between the defenders and striker.
- Look for the wide players when they have room.
- When we lose the ball, protect the space in front of our defenders.

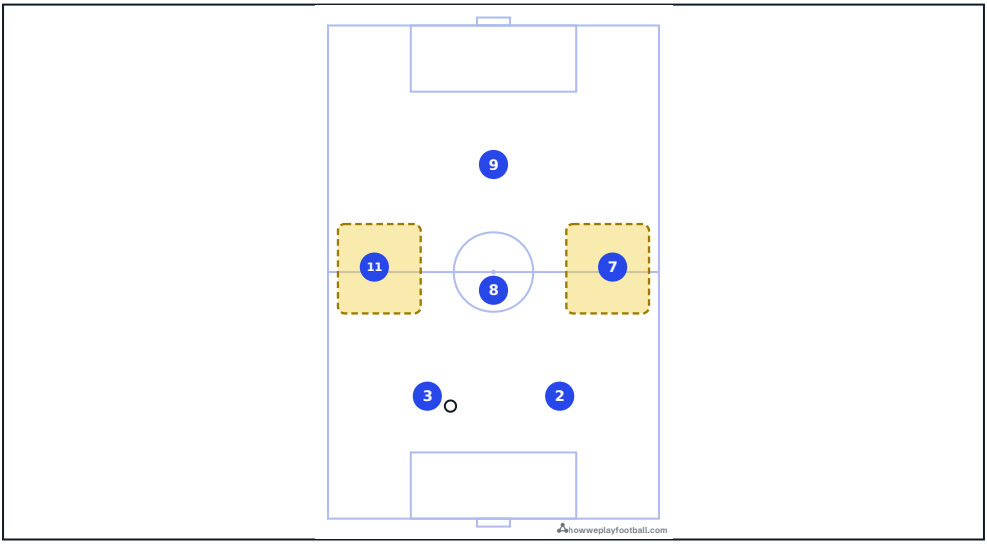
ASK YOURSELF

“CAN I HELP THE PLAYER ON THE BALL?”

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

11 · 7 WIDE MIDFIELDERS

Wide with it. Closer without.



YOUR JOBS

- When we have the ball, use the space near the touchlines to help the team spread out.
- Show a clear angle for a pass and be willing to run with the ball.
- When the opposition have the ball, come closer to the middle and help your teammates.

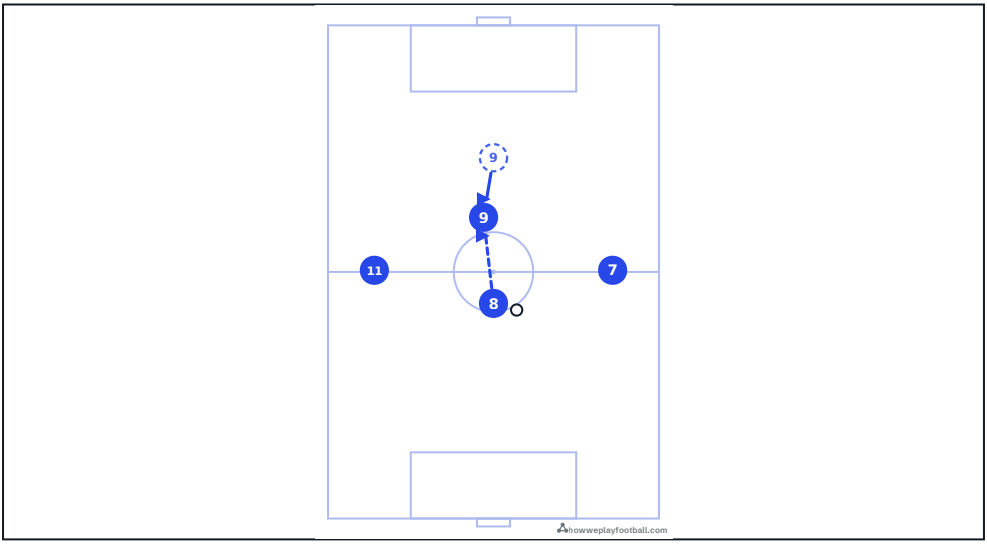
ASK YOURSELF

“WHERE IS THE BALL, AND WHO NEEDS ME?”

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

9 STRIKER

Give us somewhere to play



YOUR JOBS

- Stay available ahead so we have somewhere to play forwards.
- Sometimes show towards the ball to support 8 and the wide players.
- At other times, threaten space behind the defenders to create room for teammates.
- When the opposition build, help slow their options instead of chasing everyone.

ASK YOURSELF

“DO WE NEED A SHORT PASS OR SPACE AHEAD?”

YOUR NOTES

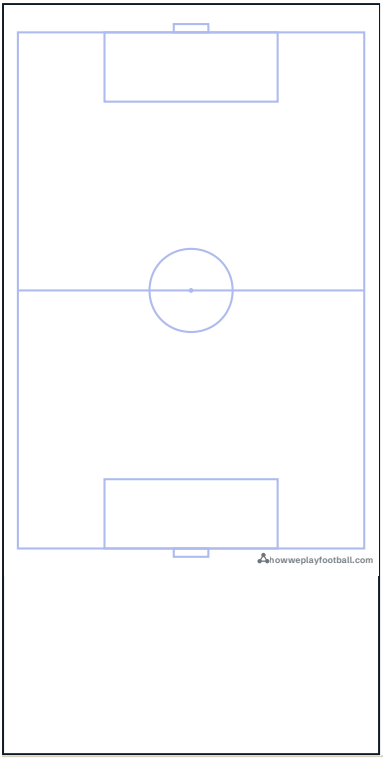
ON THE TOUCHLINE

01 Can our keeper see two choices?

02 Ball ours? Wide. Ball theirs? Closer.

03 If your mate goes, where do you cover?

04 Who slows them? Where do I help?



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Helping your team take the next step.

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